

Connected appliances

Turning lights on by speaking to them may sound like science fiction, but internet-connected household devices allow people to do this and much more.

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Smart appliances and how they work

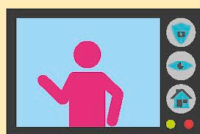
Smart appliances are home devices and gadgets that are controlled using apps on a smartphone, or via interactive panels in the home. The earliest smart homes appeared in the 1970s when a Scottish company called Pico Electronics introduced the X10 system. This system allowed people to control electrical devices in their homes using a central computer controller and their existing electrical wiring system. Nowadays, devices include tiny computers that can connect to smartphones via Bluetooth or Wi-Fi, allowing users to control their devices, even when they are not physically at home.

IN DEPTH

Benefits of a connected home

A home installed with smart devices has a number of benefits. Instead of worrying about having left a computer on, a user can check the device's status and switch it off via their smartphone. An indoor positioning system (IPS) can locate objects and people inside a house using sensory information. Smart appliance apps also give users access to data about how long they have been used for, and how much energy they have used.

A connected security system can make the house safer.



Some smart devices can send a video feed to the home owner so they can decide whether to open the door or not.

◀ Home security systems

Internet-connected devices can be used to keep people safe and secure at home. Smart locks can open the front door automatically for approved people, but keep strangers out. Smart smoke alarms can turn electrical appliances off if they detect smoke or carbon monoxide, and even alert the emergency services.



A digital assistant can send a command to close the garage door.

Voice commands can be used to operate a smart device.

Close the garage door!

▷ Digital assistants

A digital assistant is a small device that uses the internet to answer questions put to them by an owner. They can also be linked up to smart devices in the home and used to control things such as lighting, doors, and temperature.

